Indians were never – apart from one brief but significant foray into South East Asia by the Imperial Cholas in the eleventh century – colonisers.

That is one way of looking at it. A more prosaic approach would be to say that I have come to Kanyakumari, better known outside India as Cape Comorin, to stand on the very tip of that geophysical marvel the Indian Plate, overlooking the confluence of three great watery deeps: the Bay of Bengal, the Arabian Sea and the Indian Ocean.

I am, to be quite honest, a tad disappointed. With so much drama in its making I had expected Kanyakumari to be more special. Perhaps I expected it to resemble the pen-and-ink and wash drawing (see page 17) executed by the geologist Robert Bruce Foote shortly after his arrival in India in 1860 to join the newly established Geological Survey of India. Foote is one of those undervalued pioneers who helped lay the groundwork for what we take for granted today; in his case, Indian geology and Indian prehistory, which earned him the title of ‘father of Indian prehistory’. On 30 May 1863 Foote recognised a Palaeolithic hand-axe lying on the parade-ground at Pallavaram cantonment, just outside Madras, for what it was. He went on to discover many more Stone Age tools and settlements in South India, so beginning the first systematic research into early human history in India.

Over the course of five decades of geological surveying in South India Foote located and identified something close to four hundred prehistoric sites. After his official retirement in 1903 he continued to write and publish up to the end of his life in 1912. His ashes lie in Holy Trinity Church in the little hill-station of Yercaud, in Tamil Nadu’s Shevaroy Hills.

Foote’s vast collection of palaeoliths and other Stone Age artefacts laid the foundations for the early history department in the Chennai Museum. But Foote was primarily a geologist, and his drawing makes the point very nicely: the rocks were there first.